A Century of Light

How one family kept a lighthouse burning

The lighthouse at Skarvik was lit for the first time on a wet October evening in 1871, and for almost a century afterwards the same family kept its lamp burning. Their log books survive in the town archive: eleven volumes of weather, ships, repairs and the occasional complaint about the price of paraffin.

Most entries are short. Wind from the south-west, fresh; visibility good; two steamers northbound before midnight. But every few pages the keeper allowed himself a sentence more, and those sentences are the reason people still read the logs today.

In the winter of 1893 the ice reached the outer skerries, something no one in the village had seen before. The keeper walked across to the nearest island with his son, measured the ice with an auger and wrote that it was thicker than the kitchen table and twice as level.

The station was modernised in stages. A clockwork rotation mechanism replaced the hand-cranked one in 1902, an acetylene burner arrived in 1923, and electricity followed in 1951, carried across the sound on a cable that the fishermen swore would never hold.

Daily life followed the light. The lamp was trimmed at dusk and dawn, the lens polished every morning, and the brass fittings once a week whether they needed it or not. Supplies came by boat every second Thursday, weather permitting, which in February it rarely did.

Visitors were rare and were recorded with care: a priest in 1880, a painter who stayed for three weeks in 1911 and left a small oil sketch of the tower, and a group of surveyors whose instruments, the log notes drily, were less reliable than the keeper's barometer.

When the light was automated in 1968 the last keeper moved to a house in the village from which, on clear nights, he could see the beam sweep past his window every twelve seconds. He kept writing the log for another two years, out of habit.

Today the tower belongs to a foundation that opens it to the public in summer. The log books have been scanned, transcribed and indexed, and a small exhibition in the old oil store shows the lamp, the auger and a page from the winter of 1893.

The transcription project took four years and relied almost entirely on volunteers. Handwriting changed from keeper to keeper, abbreviations drifted, and the ink of the earliest volumes had faded to the colour of weak tea, so every page was read twice by different people.

What emerges from the logs is not a story of heroism but of attention: a century of people who looked at the same stretch of sea every day and wrote down what they saw, so that others could find their way home in the dark.